



“ Everytime I bat, I feel I have to make every innings count. ”

GAUTAM GAMBHIR, INDIA OPENER

more compact, with every sign that he could do justice to his talent”.

The more justice he's done, the more secure Gambhir has become and it has fed into his game. He says security has made him more certain about his mental preparation, and his physical preparation, says Bhargava, has remained a constant. Returning home by 5 a.m. the night after winning a car in a T20 international, Gambhir was in the nets at 2 p.m. The day after returning from New Zealand, he went to the gym.

His is now one of the first names to be put down on an Indian XI in all forms of the game. He makes the switch between formats by sticking to

his basic game plan: be positive, look to score. Test cricket, he says reflexively, is “actual cricket”, where the preparation needed is more intense. “In T20 you play with freedom and improvise a lot more, but that's it.”

The Gambhir-Sehwag partnership now promises India both entertainment and folklore. Sehwag thinks of himself as a makeshift opener and Gambhir says he became an opener only because he hated waiting to bat. Their reputation is already well-travelled as is Gambhir's for his sometimes fiery nature. During the 2007-2008 Ranji final, he fought to

have his team transported in an air-conditioned bus and gave a stirring pre-game speech. During the match, Gambhir almost scraped the skin right off one hand while fielding and then, ignoring the queasy faces in the dressing room, pulled on his gloves, to front the second innings chase that won the title for Delhi after 16 years.

He's still competitive but wants to temper that temper. A one-Test ban when in form for elbowing Shane Watson actually worked better than the pearls tied around his neck by his mother worried about her otherwise good-natured son's incendiary streak. Gambhir said, “It was irresponsible. I let my team down, and we had worked so hard... had we not won the series, I would put the blame on myself.”

It may seem like Gambhir takes everything about his cricket personally but India has no complaints. After all, it is the reason for this astonishing coming of age. ■